

Q Over the years, we have seen Microsoft becoming more and more focused on establishing a connection with the open source community. What has been the reason behind this?

We understand that open source software alternatives can represent healthy competition and an opportunity to complement or enhance Microsoft technologies and products. We also share the common industry view that software users will continue to see a mixed IT environment of open source and proprietary products, for years to come.

We recognise the value of openness when working with others (including open source communities), to help customers and partners succeed in today's heterogeneous IT environments. This includes increasing opportunities for developers to learn and create, by combining community-oriented open source with traditional commercial approaches to software development.

Hence, the company is working towards establishing a long-term community connection, and is also trying to build bridges between Microsoft and non-Microsoft technologies.

Our open source strategy is to make Windows the platform of choice for customers and developers, by enabling open source applications to run better on, and with, Windows platforms. We view interoperability as a lever for growth, and are committed to helping our customers thrive in a mixed-source world.

Q Can you tell us about a few projects in which you are working closely with the open source community?

For the last three years, we have been working with the Eclipse Foundation, and have built long-term credibility on various projects. One of the biggest challenges with regard to Eclipse has been to improve its performance on Windows. Let me tell you that there is no vested interest involved in Microsoft improving Eclipse. On the contrary, it has been a challenge to get it prioritised, and fund it. This effort requires a long-term strategy, which we are working on.

We are also working with many open source communities to identify opportunities to participate in projects and initiatives, focusing on improved open source application interoperability with our products. If it makes sense for specific products and solutions, we use an open source development approach, or even open source software itself. A very good example here is the PHP SDK for Windows Azure.

The results of these initiatives—whether it is Java and Ruby SDKs for .NET Services for Azure, or our ongoing OS projects that will help Web developers support digital identity information cards—are ample proof of our seriousness to embrace, and be guided by the open source philosophy.

Q Is interoperability the only talking point that Microsoft has when it comes to open source?

On the contrary, our engagement with open source is fairly comprehensive, and interoperability is just one of the elements—although a core element—of the entire equation. Our investment and participation in open source is as broad and deep as any other company in the industry today—resulting in more choice for customers, more opportunities for developers, and more technology innovation and market competition for businesses, governments and consumers.

While our business model leads many to believe that we only support proprietary software, in truth, we do value openness. And as a company, we've learned a tremendous amount, over the years, about the value of openness and open source in markets across the world, including India.

Q With respect to India, what are the goals set for encouraging interoperability?

We have observed that there is an increasing customer and partner concern around interoperability, especially when it comes to customer flexibility and choice. Based on the feedback from customers and partners, and through years of participation in industry organisations and forums, we have outlined four foundational interoperability elements of a cloud platform, which include:

- 1) *Data portability* to help customers retain data ownership and control
- 2) *Focus on standards* to support existing and evolving standards that make it easier to interconnect
- 3) *Ease of migration and deployment* that simplifies the process of migrating existing IT assets to the cloud, and
- 4) *Developer choice* in skills and preferences for tools, languages, run-times and more.

Windows Azure was also designed from the ground up with interoperability in mind.

We have a global interoperability strategy to facilitate the development of open source tools on our platforms. We are also open to receiving inputs from the community, which we plan to club with our plan.

Our recent experience at *Open Source India 2010* has also helped us gain interesting insights on the subject of interoperability. During the event, we tried to understand the open source market in India, particularly from the developers' perspective.

Q But why is Microsoft so keen on investing in open source projects like Eclipse and PHP?

It is strategic for us. The reasons are more than one. We want distinguished technologies to be widely adopted. We have a team at our Redmond centre that is dedicated to building open source bridges between the Microsoft platform and important open source projects, such as Windows Azure SDKs for Java and PHP, and Windows Azure tools for Eclipse. Each of these includes an SDK, source code, and documentation. (See www.